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Dick Katz

Pianist Dick Katz was born in Baltimore, Maryland on March 13,1924. He studied piano at the Manhattan School of Music and received on-the-job training with J.J. Johnson and Kai Winding. Dick has performed and recorded with a long list of jazz luminaries including Benny Carter, Sonny Rollins and Roy Eldridge. He co-founded Milestone Records with Orrin Keepnews in 1966.

Dick was interviewed in New York City on January 7, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Manhattan. I'm very, very pleased to have Dick Katz with me today, pianist and arranger, and veteran of the New York scene. Is that a decent introduction?

DK: Yeah that's okay.

MR: Okay. I think I was going to —

DK: They've got me to write a lot recently too, not in the last few years.

MR: To be a writer?

DK: I've written a lot of stuff.

MR: Great. Let me read something that was said about you in the *New Grove Encyclopedia of Jazz*.

DK: It's all wrong.

MR: Well it says—

DK: It's my fault I never corrected it. They sent a form years ago, and I never sent it in.

MR: Well this is just a description.

DK: Okay.

MR: He says, "He has an eclectic style which reflects to some degree Teddy Wilson but also draws inspiration from Thelonious Monk and Bill Evans."

DK: Okay. Among others. But that part in there about West Coast — what does it say?

MR: Oh —

DK: They've got it all wrong. I've never worked on the West Coast.

MR: Okay.

DK: So they lump me together with those guys.

MR: We can correct that today.

DK: Okay.

MR: Was Baltimore a good place to grow up in as far as music?

DK: No. But it was for me.

MR: You almost said yes, and then you said no.

DK: I thought you meant as a city. No but that's like that guy says in there, you see that movie "The Tannenbaums?"

MR: I haven't seen it yet.

DK: He said — Gene Hackman, the daughter — he's got a bunch of dysfunctional kids, so one of the daughters says, "You don't even know my middle name." And he says, "That's a trick question."

MR: Okay.

DK: Um what I mean was that Baltimore normally would not be a good place to grow up in music, it wasn't any main scene. There were two scenes, there was a white jazz scene and a black jazz scene, which is not unusual, that's the American Way at that time, and I gravitated, there was a very lively black scene down the strip called Pennsylvania Avenue which was sort of the 125th Street of Baltimore. And they had a theater which was the Baltimore counterpart of the Apollo. It was called the Royal Theater. And everybody played there, all the bands. And so I used to hang out there as a teenager. I was totally smitten. When I went to see Duke Ellington one time and the band rose out of the — you've heard this story before — well I mean for your generation I don't know who it was but I don't think it was the Beatles, whatever, to see this orchestra rise out of the floor on a riser, you know, behind the scrim, and they're in white tails, and Sonny Greer is on like a throne behind the band with the chimes and whatever, and then to hear that sound and see Duke, I mean that was epiphany. Well that was one of the things. I saw Fats Waller down there. I saw everybody. And that had a big effect on me. And my brother fortunately was a pioneer record collector, when nobody where I grew up, very few knew or cared about jazz or collected. He and his buddy bought these 78s as they came out for 35 cents a piece, of all the greats, Louis Armstrong, so I used to hear all this stuff around the house all the time. And that started me really. And you will hear variations on this from a lot of musicians. Older brother or something, some event or something that drew them in.

MR: You got it in your ear.

DK: Got it in my ear and there was an interesting wrinkle to this though, he used to play me a lot of Benny Goodman records and he and his buddy would make me dance when I was a little kid and all this kind of — you know he was six years older than me, so he's like—

MR: Yup, he ruled the roost as far as you're concerned.

DK: He ruled my roost. I don't know about your family but — you got an older brother?

MR: Yup.

DK: Okay. So I didn't pay much attention, I liked it all right, and then my mother would make me take piano lessons at the Peabody Conservatory which I was not a good student. I really cheated 'cause I didn't really want to learn to read so I used to watch this fat lady

play, I would watch her hands and imitate her. So it didn't really take, but let's see, the first one to turn me on was Fats Waller. My brother had these Fats Waller records. And the way he played the piano, still, if you listen, it had an equilibrium and a balance, it's very rare even now. And there were certain little figures. I didn't really — I tried a little bit to play like him, but like a lot of kids I would just imitate little licks here and there. And early on I realized well I'm not really ever going to be a real stride player. And I had one experience which I wrote about and I wrote the notes to — oh I'm skipping around now a little bit — but one of the first in quotes big time experiences I had was working at Minton's Playhouse, the fabled Minton's Playhouse with a clarinetist named Tony Scott. And I really liked — trial by fire with Philly Joe Jones and Milt Hinton and Tony, and the girl singer was Carmen McRae. So I made one of her first records, it was called something — I forgot the name. Anyhow the two albums I did with her have been reissued from Decca and I wrote — I was asked to write the notes for them. So in writing the notes I told this story about the Royal Theater and Fats Waller and all this stuff. Now wait a minute now, let me get this straight. I don't know if it was for that LP or not, I'm trying to remember which. I really should cancel this segment. I'll tell you why, because I want to get it right. What I'm getting at is the story about Fats Waller, was I was asked — this older record collector friend of mine who still lives down there, used to go down to the Royal and when all those big names would come in he would hang around backstage and present them with rare 78s they'd forgotten they'd even made. So he dragged me along one day and he made me play for Fats. I was about 16 or 17, in the basement of the theater. So I wrote about that. And he was one of the first. And then one day when I was about 13 or 14 he had left this stack of records on top of the record player, my brother, and he says, "Don't you dare ever touch those if I'm not here." Of course I did. So the first ones I pulled off were the first Count Basie records on Decca. Okay? I put it on. When I heard that rhythm section and Lester Young, the whole thing turned around. Just grabbed me. Whatever that was, I wanted to go that way. So experiences like that helped me and I used to go down, as I got a little older and I was learning to play, teach myself to play a little bit, I had a friend a trombone player and we would play and I used to play in a high school band, we used to play stock arrangements. You'll hear this experience a lot too from other musicians from local bands. And I worked little gigs around Baltimore. I knew about four tunes.

MR: But were you reading like chord symbols at the time? Could you do that?

DK: Barely.

MR: Mostly finding your part by ear?

DK: Yeah. Which blows my mind now, you know like I teach at Manhattan School of Music. And what these kids have today, available to them, I could sit you here all day and talk about the whole education scene, IAJE and the whole thing.

MR: Right.

DK: Where are these people going to play this? I went to the last convention, seven thousand.

MR: I know I went too. It was like overwhelming.

DK: It's bigger than what they're training for.

MR: And all the musicians, it seems like all the jazz musicians, either by choice or necessity, have their educational part of what they do, because that's where the money is.

DK: And for many it's the main thing. For instance a terrific pianist named Harold Danko, who is a full time professor at Eastman jazz, I took over his course at Manhattan School, this one course. The main part of his career is teaching now, because that's security. There comes a point when, if you're not a traveling musician now, and part of a permanent group, you either have to be a marketed star, made a star by the marketing mostly, and all that goes with that a manager and a record contract and the publicity and the whole thing, and then you get your group or not a group, you're either that or you're part of a group, or you teach. There's very few. You know there's Monty Alexander, there are a few musicians who make a living just traveling. But I'm beginning to think they're the minority and I don't really know, but the vast majority of musicians, mostly white incidentally, are in the education field. It's a huge industry now.

MR: And as you said what is the product they're turning out?

DK: I don't know where these kids can play. And I mean to editorialize about it, the one thing that's changed from when I was coming up it was essential that you find your own personality somehow. Eclectic or not, you had to be recognizable. Now I can't tell — there are a few really talented individuals out there, but the rest are like — like the whole society.

MR: Is that because of all the tools they have available?

DK: It's the tools and it's the culture. There is no emphasis on individuality anymore as a prized thing to strive for. Skills are it. Skills and versatility. I'm being — it's a big assumption on my part but I would think that would go into many, many areas outside of music, in the corporate world and everything, there's always a place — if the guy has got some real ideas, yeah, he'll be all right. But the pressure to conform is very strong. The way they teach modal jazz, you learn your scales, yeah, and you find out which fourth chords will go with it, and if you've got the chops you've got instant solos. See? Where the real artists don't approach it that way, including McCoy Tyner and Chick Corea. They don't think "I'm playing a Lydian in M-1 now go on to this." They're composing on the spot. The people I admire are composers, instant composers. And that means you

have to know how to develop an idea. You may or may not involve modal harmony. I don't think Miles sat around doing that when they made "Kind of Blue" you know? Bill Evans was a very intellectual musicians and he knew — yes he knew about that — but that wasn't his whole thing. All right so —

MR: I agree because sometimes I look at the transcribed solos in some of the magazines you know and they analyze just about every note and how it related to the chord and look how this augmented ninth was — and I cannot believe that the players were thinking that.

DK: No. That's — Lester Young barely knew chords. In other words, yes, it's a valuable tool if you have an artistic sensibility to know what to do with it, great. But if you don't you're a mechanic. That's the cynical view.

MR: Okay. Well you found yourself pursuing music, I wonder if your parents were in favor of that?

DK: Oh well my father was a very creative duck. He was very eccentric and I was well prepared for all the crazy people I was going to be involved with. My whole family is a little bit crazy, except my sister, she was a straight arrow. And my brother went to a place — you probably never heard of — Black Mountain College, but that was a place in North Carolina, it was almost like a commune. And they had really prestigious people teaching there but it was very small. Anyhow no, they weren't. My mother was sure I would starve to death and my father was an advertising person. He was successful and very creative, but a real individual. And he alternately encouraged me and discouraged me. So that's a psychological thing. But what happened was I got more and more passionately involved with the music. And I used to spend a lot of time in the black section of Baltimore sitting in with some fantastic local players, who incidentally, every city had or probably has these people. You'd hear Miles or Dizzy or this one talk about this great guy in this town that never left. In other words somebody like Wes Montgomery would have never left Indianapolis if Cannonball hadn't found him and pushed him out there, that kind of thing. So I used to sit in with a trumpet player named Stanford East, and he had this little quintet that was a cross between the Louis Jordan Tympani Five and the Basie small group.

MR: The octet?

DK: No, like the records that made "Shoeshine Boy" and all that. They had that kind of feel. And that grabbed me. Because on the other side of town they were playing Dixieland or whatever they called it. But there was a great pianist I used to follow around who made a big reputation, his name was Don Ewell. E-W-E-L-L. And his brother was a trombone player. They had a band that sounded like Bob Crosby's Bobcats. A terrific band. But Don was brilliant — he wound up playing duets with Willie "The Lion" Smith in New York and he was with Jack Teagarden many years, and he was a true — he started out as

a contemporary, what was then contemporary. He used to sound a little like Teddy Wilson and Jess Stacey. That was contemporary when he came up. But then after the war he went back and he became like Jelly Roll Morton. He was not original but he was identifiable. In other words the idea is if you're going to pick a style to play in, that's okay, as long as you're recognizable. Like Scott Hamilton. They thought he was crazy, you know, this kid coming around. In the meantime there's Coltrane, and here's this kid sounds like Flip Phillips or Don Byas or whatever, but it's him, and it sounds like him as opposed to guys who just copy and you don't know who they are if you go like that. So this little group I used to go sit in with, and the trumpet player took me aside and he taught me chords. I used to go to his house. And then I wound up in the Navy. No first I went to the University of North Carolina and I got in a college band there. It was quite an experience because I used to play in the student lounge, right? You know I'm playing, so these two very imperious, regal looking guys, full of confidence, Wayne Fulton Denning was the trumpet player, and the trombone player's name was Bud Montgomery. And these guys were terrific. And they had taken over this band which was a pretty well known band in the south. And they asked me if I wanted to join the band. And I said I had zero experience. So I gulped, and I remember hearing, and they used to play Basie stocks. Didn't have any original arrangements. But see that's — now they have to pay guys to transcribe this stuff. You could go in the store and buy "Down for Double" and all these great, "Tuesday in Town" all these great arrangements of the 1940s bands. So we used to play those. But when I heard them play it almost blew me off the chair. I didn't know what the hell I was doing and I had a crash course. I don't know how I kept the job. And then we used to go around weekends and play all these fancy girls schools. It was a great education. And the guy that played third tenor in the band, a little skinny kid named Bud Shank played in that. Some guys, most of those guys didn't even wind up being musicians probably. And Bud Montgomery, I remember he played like Urbie Green. He could play like that, I'm not kidding you. There are people you never heard of that do that. Maybe at Hamilton. You don't know. So that was my early experience. And in the Navy I wound up in the Navy band and I went to the Pacific for a while and all that. And when I got back, instead of going back to the University of North Carolina to get my degree, I had about two and a half years down there before I went in the Navy, I moved to New York, I got married and moved to New York and went to Manhattan School of Music. And who did I find there? Who became my mentor and dearest, dearest friend was John Lewis. Max Roach was there, all the — Juilliard didn't take them. That business about Miles at Juilliard, I don't know how that happened with those guys. Because there was no jazz at Juilliard or Manhattan except when I graduated from Manhattan I still had some credits over, and Teddy Wilson, one of my real idols, was

teaching a course of jazz piano at Juilliard. The only one. It wasn't a course it was like three or four guys that you'd go in and you'd play for him and it was almost like individual lessons with just a few. And I guess he was there because of his name, I don't know, because there was no jazz program. And I always wondered how do guys like Miles go there? He didn't study —

MR: He didn't study classical, yeah.

DK: I just don't know how he got in. Because I didn't get in, I applied to Juilliard and I had to play a rigid classical repertoire, and they said well you play okay but this is for really serious classical advanced students and we have too many now so I was sort of discouraged. But I applied to Manhattan. This is interesting because I went in there and they had similar entrance requirements, this little old lady named Janet Schenck who was the head of the school, this classical maven and she was a wealthy social activist. It started out as a settlement house, the Manhattan School of Music, and she was this incredible character. So she says, I started to play my classical thing, I got halfway through a Mozart sonata and she said, "Oh that's nice but it says here that you play jazz music. Would you play something for me?" So I don't know what I played. She says, "You'll be fine."

MR: All right.

DK: She just understood intuitively that she just was that broadminded. And I'm sure a lot of jazz people got in that way. So it was a very lively time I had there, and I became friends with John and I started working gigs around town. My first close friend was, I lived over a little nightclub called the Little Casino and one of the five pianists there was Ram Ramirez, the guy that wrote "Lover Man." Wonderful piano player. So I became friends with him and then I joined the union and I started playing jobs and somewhere along the line Tony Scott got in the act and he collected me. He was like this wild egomaniac gifted man. And we wound up at Minton's and that was like a postgraduate degree.

MR: I'll bet.

DK: Oh man. Monday nights was jam session night, and everybody would come in and I got bumped off the bandstand by the best, including Bud Powell.

MR: How would that happen? Getting bumped off the bench?

DK: How would that happen? You're playing along and this guy's standing over your shoulder says, "Get up." And you look and you see it's Bud Powell. And you're not in a position to say sorry. I mean you could but you don't. So he would sit down and play like 20 choruses of "Crazy Rhythm" without ever once playing the bridge. But it didn't matter. I had some fantastic experiences up there.

MR: Who else would have been in those jam sessions at that time?

DK: Good question. I don't know. A lot of guys I wound up playing with later in Oscar Pettiford's band, the guys like Jimmy Cleveland and Jerome Richardson, and Donald Byrd. Well that was later, when the Detroit — that's another thing — in 1956 there was this mass immigration from Detroit that took over the town. It wasn't mass, it was maybe a handful of people but they were all great.

MR: The Jones brothers.

DK: There's something in the water in Detroit. I'm convinced. Because all these guys had the same thing. I called it, it was their version of Charlie Parker, it was this line, this lyrical line that they all knew how to play, like Pepper Adams, Tommy Flanagan, Barry Harris, Billy Mitchell, who wasn't really from Detroit but he wound up there, Paul Chambers, Kenny Burrell, I'm probably leaving out some. Roland was a little bit different, Roland Hanna. Because he was basically classical pianist that switched to jazz on the influence of Tommy, just a great pianist. And they were amazing. So I played with Tony, I made my first — I made my first record with him.

MR: Tony Scott?

DK: Yup. And they're good records. The first one was done — not the very first one, the first one was at an Army camp in New Jersey with Milt and I forget who the drummer was, and Tony. We played jobs all over. But when you got this Minton's gig, it was about now, the early part of 1953, we were there about six months almost, it was really a fantastic gig, and the group got really tight. It was with Philly Joe and Milt and this was before — just between the time Milt went in, was with Cab Calloway and the time that he went in to studios and became this incredible all things to all men person.

MR: Was it out of the ordinary for this — this was an integrated group at the time — was it out of the ordinary?

DK: Yes, but not as much as it is now in a way. I mean curiously now — this should be another discussion. I didn't feel any problem. I have felt the problem at various times but not this time. I don't know why. It would be interesting to go into that. But later, you know bebop had a social agenda as you probably know, when I say bebop I mean that's not a secret — I don't know if they did it consciously or not — but when Kenny Clarke and Monk and Dizzy and all those people made that music at Minton's, part of the rationale was to come up with something that the white guys couldn't copy so easy. And beyond that the idea that the time for jazz to be Vaudevillians had to stop. Because the fact of the matter is, and a lot of critics know this, I think the younger critics might have a better handle on it, but some of the older critics had this kind of — I'm not going to name names — the earliest critics, this is just my opinion, I'm editorializing now, this is strictly my opinion, and still prevails in certain quarters, where they look at black jazz musicians as some kind of noble savages. I'm using that phrase, it's a cliché phrase. What it means

is these guys are gifted they're geniuses, but somehow or other it's also natural and they're different. They don't need to be educated and they just came full blown from the head of Zeus — and French people particularly had that kind of attitude. And that ain't the way it is, or was. And the facts are that the society at the time said white or black, if you wanted to make a living playing this kind of music you must entertain with it. You can't just stand up there and play music to listen to. That's not what it's about. That's all later when they decided it was an art. But I mean all the bands had a show. Even Benny Goodman, he had show business features to it. Although Benny got away with less than most. And the black bands, they all, even Duke, I mean Duke, well he was a genius because he was a virtuoso social person. He knew how to play the music exactly as he wanted to play it and make them think he's entertaining them. I don't know how he pulled this off but he did. Even though that's another subject. But he never lost his dignity. But a lot of black guys were — now Louis Armstrong, you know he caught a lot of flack for the so-called Uncle — but he wasn't really Uncle Tom, that's another—

MR: No. And he liked what he was doing, right?

DK: He liked what he was doing. That's another subject we won't go into. But to give you a general answer I mean whether it was Fats Waller singing, I mean I think if he wanted to he, I mean he was a master pianist, I'm sure he enjoyed singing, but all that junk he had to sing, I mean there's a lot of cynicism there. He's making fun of all these songs. I think there's no pat theories about it because — and I make statements like this and at the same time I'm talking like this I'm thinking of Dizzy Gillespie, the purest improviser, I mean didn't compromise a note but my God he was like a latter day Louis jumping around and he's clowning and he's joking. So he's like an exception, right? And he realized — well what I think he did was when you make a mark like that he probably figured look I came up with the new music, now I've got to eat. And the big band was a failure, financially. He lost his shirt, got ripped off. So I guess that must have been a turning point where he said I've got to do something, work all the time, so he had his little quintet and he's singing "Eat More Meat, Pete" or whatever the heck it was "Pete eat More," and all those things, and on the other hand some guys slightly younger, Miles, I'm not going to do that. Miles was a spoiled rich kid. So he could afford to do that. So everybody's got a story so it's a little bit dangerous for me to generalize. But to make a broad brush statement which is before Charlie Parker and Dizzy came up with those historic records and the music got a real foothold, you had to entertain on some level. And the music they were making was a statement about that, where they took it to extremes, where Miles turned his back on the audience and all that.

MR: And the response from the audience was predictable, wasn't it?

DK: Yeah but they loved it. They used to go and see if he was going to show up?

MR: Really?

DK: Well I used to work, okay I'll get back to me chronologically. So after Tony Scott I started working with Kai Winding and J.J. Johnson. Kai and Jay. Very successful. The most successful commercial group I'd ever — he had some hit records. And the group was a great experience because it was very tightly organized. And I made about six albums with them. I'm still waiting for them to be on CD. We recorded for Columbia with Paul Chambers and Kenny Clarke and I was spoiled that way. Even now, like because I played with all these great people, like if I get a group now and like drummers, some of them are great but you can't get them and I'm not in a position to do that although a recent gig I had at the Charlie Parker Festival I played with one of the young drummers who I think would have more than held his own in the old days, his name is Lewis Nash. He's really terrific. He's great. And George Mraz is George Mraz. But what was I saying just before that?

MR: We were talking about the group with J.J. and Kai.

DK: Oh. J.J. and Kai. We traveled a lot and we had records and it was a remarkable group because of how well they organized it. J.J. was — they were very different. Even — they played similarly but not, they're really different if you listen. J.J. was smooth, controlled and Kai was sort of brash. But they were in the idiom and they were great foils for each other and they devised all these arrangements with mutes and everything. It was a terrific experience. And our last gig was at the 1956 Newport festival and we went in the studio and made one more album and then they went their separate ways and J.J. had this great successful career and Kai, Kai interestingly wanted to get out of jazz. He wanted money. So he started — a lot of critics, they just don't get it. They think that just 'cause you play great you're not entitled to make a lot of money.

MR: Yeah. You should be fulfilled just because — and it is interesting. It's like we want our artists to be — we want them to suffer almost. It makes us feel better or something.

DK: Talk to the musicians.

MR: I know, and then they dump on people like Doc Severinsen or whoever, who have found a way to play music and become well-to-do.

DK: Yeah. They used to dump on Brubeck because he got his picture in *Time*.

MR: Yeah. And he was just playing, and continues to do, to play what he wants.

DK: He's never compromised a note.

MR: Interesting. Were you able, at this point, we're talking about mid 50s to late 50s, you're actually making a living doing this? Kind of?

DK: I have to confess that I had some help from my family. I was making a living but I was doing better than if I was just playing the music with my family's help. Because the only white guys I know that were making a living, there were very few white musicians who

actually made a living just playing jazz. In other words, guys like Al Cohn and Johnny Mandel, a whole school of guys, they were doing commercial work. Arranging or playing all kinds of studio dates. They became studio musicians. There was just a handful, like Stan Getz and Zoot, who didn't want, I mean he was the exception because he was a true Bohemian or whatever they called them.

MR: And those guys would often times, wouldn't they just tour as soloists and play with—

DK: Play with local rhythm. That's right.

MR: So they didn't have the headache or expense of trying to hold a band together.

DK: No. I worked with them a lot in the old Half Note, I used to work down there. And let's see, you want to point me, now let's see after, oh yeah, the best job I had, after I left Kai and J.J. and was freelancing with everybody, I played with — I was in the house rhythm section at the Café Bohemia with Oscar Pettiford and Kenny Clarke. That was one of the greatest experiences. And we used to have different horn players — Art Farmer, Donald Byrd, Gigi Gryce.

MR: Jerome Richardson?

DK: Jerome Richardson, Gigi Gryce, one weekend it was Miles. And that rhythm section, that's the best I ever had anything to do with. Those two people were — now on Tony's first record we did — well the first one — well I'm going to back up a little bit. I wish they'd reissue those records. One night up at Minton's the first time we were there with the three, a guy who I befriended named Johnny Mandel, who was one of these guys, he played jazz bass trumpet and he used to write arrangements for Elliot Lawrence and all different people. He was in that — Al Cohn, Tiny Kahn, all these great guys. Johnny one night brought his — he had a professional tape machine he lugged around. Concord that's what it was, a big reel to reel. He lugged it all the way up to Minton's and he recorded us, the Tony Scott Quartet. So Tony took the tapes to the late Bob Thiele, you heard that name?

MR: Sure.

DK: Who is running Brunswick. And he put it out on ten inch. I still have it, it's a real souvenir, that was my first.

MR: All right.

DK: Yeah. Then we went in the studio. Then the next year we went back there with Osie Johnson and Earl May who's still out here.

MR: Yes indeed.

DK: I saw him recently. And you ought to interview him.

MR: I did. He's a good guy.

DK: Isn't he great?

MR: Yeah.

DK: And we went in the studio and Percy Heath played on it. Okay so fast forward again and here I am with Oscar Pettiford and all these, and I was not there the night, bad luck, that Cannonball came in.

MR: I was just going to ask.

DK: I wasn't there that night. Damn.

MR: Who was taking your place do you know?

DK: I don't know probably Horace Silver or somebody. I don't know. He broke the piano. I remember one night Horace broke the piano. It was a little spinet and — oh he was playing opposite me, that's right — and all the hammers had been knocked off — it was a mess. I loved Horace, I thought he was great. And then I used to work in the Embers. One night I got a — Hank Jones, one of my all time heroes, he's incredible, he was so in demand that he would take, say yes to three jobs and then at the last minute he'd decide which one he was going to take, then he'd make these panicky calls to get — so one night he called — would I sub for him at The Embers. The Embers was a fancy steakhouse on the East side where they had soft jazz, muted trumpet, Jonah Jones and so on and so on. But they had Art Tatum in there once playing for the diners. They didn't even keep quiet for him. One pianist that shut that room up — it was Erroll Garner. Because he did it with dynamics. He'd be roaring away and all of a sudden he'd drop down.

MR: People would stop.

DK: That's right. He was a magician. Not that Tatum — so Hank says, "Can you go on and take this" so it turned out to be like two months or something. It was Tyree Glenn, Papa Jo Jones who was the real leader, Tyree was the front man, and Tommy Potter. And it was very well structured and Jo didn't care too much for Tyree I think because Tyree used to really lay it on thick.

MR: How so?

DK: He'd roll his eyes around and Texas fat cats would come in and they'd say to me, "Whatchu doin up there boy?" But Jo Jones would come to my defense, he'd say, "He's playing the piano, that's what he's doing. Go away." But Tyree was like, take any requests—

MR: You mean like he was doing the Vaudeville thing almost.

DK: Yes. He was a terrific musician but he was doing that. But it was a good job. Then I worked there with Charlie Shavers and then I would up playing with that rhythm section down back at the Bohemia with Lucky Thompson and I was in Gigi's Jazz Lab group. There is a guy writing a book about him, upstate somewhere.

MR: Really?

DK: On Gigi. He interviewed me, yeah.

MR: This is a little off the topic, but so many of the great names have been associated with untimely deaths and jazz seems to have this persona of alcohol and drug abuse. Why did that happen? I mean besides the obvious reasons, you know you're working in a nightclub, but are there other reasons for it?

DK: Well I mean to me it's conjecture, I'm not a social historian you know, but as I — I think the musical culture of the 20s, where it started, right, in speakeasies which in turn became nightclubs. Now nightclubs are not, weren't originally primarily for music, they were places to sell whisky and the music was to lure people in to buy whisky and that's the atmosphere. So if you were working these incredible hours I don't think it's a stretch to get through a night 'till three or four o'clock in the morning that it's pretty hard. And I think a lot fell in that way and they're sleeping all day and the whole thing and they're on the road, incredible, I don't know how those people survived those bus trips, particularly the black musicians. Can you imaging working for forty dollars a week riding in the bus and then you get down and there's nowhere to stay so they had to stay in rooming houses. They couldn't go in any hotels except there might have been a black hotel here and there. And of course Duke Ellington and Cab Calloway solved that problem. You know how they solved that problem?

MR: With their own—

DK: With their own railroad cars. Pullmans. Take it off site and they lived in this thing. And it's an individual matter because there are a number of people who survived all that without — you don't hear about them.

MR: Right.

DK: But back in the twenties, you know Louis sang about it, pot, gage, whatever they called it that marijuana was — but that, the alcoholism wasn't peculiar to musicians and the musicians didn't get the rap of, I think big time — for instance like the white bands and the colored bands that were really, the black bands, colored, Jimmie Lunceford and those bands, particularly bands like Jimmie Lunceford and to a lesser extent Basie, even though these guys were free spirits, the discipline in the bands was considerable. If you came to rehearsals late in Jimmie Lunceford's you'd be fined. If your suit wasn't cleaned. There was a military-like discipline in those bands. And if you drank to the point — now Duke had a system that he used to pull on Paul Gonzalves for sure, he was a world class drunk and drug addict and everything else, great as he was, he would — see if you have that kind of confidence, this is — psychologically it fascinates me. I would think that a band leader, if one of his people was screwing up that he would be embarrassed, like it'd make the band sound bad, right? They're not going to like me 'cause — Duke was the opposite. He'd say oh — he'd pull out his feature number while he's falling down drunk and make him play it. And Basie too, if he wanted to get rid of somebody he didn't fire them he

fixed it so they would fire themselves, which is a great lesson in — when you have self esteem to that level — Basie was great, he was quietly running that band but he knew what was going on. So to the alcoholism you're talking about the ones where it impacted to the point where it was messing them up would be like any other profession, you drink yourself out of a job. Of course the folklore, I mean the Charlie Parkers of the world were larger than life people. They had different physical constitution but it caught up with them, didn't it? They'd said the man was 60 years old in the morgue or something and he was 34 when he died. That kind of thing. But Dizzy — I don't think he did everything, he probably smoked pot, he never touched — my friend John Lewis, my college professor, he didn't touch anything. Horace Silver, we used to kid him, he was like, he wouldn't even drink Coke, he'd just drink — he didn't smoke or drink, and has been kidded as being a miser, is probably very wealthy. Straight arrow. Now in the middle of all this stuff Ray Brown, Oscar Peterson, there's legions of guys who don't have that problem but the attention goes on the — but if you were to make a general statement about the jazz culture right after World War II right into the fifties, yeah. Drug abuse was a big problem.

MR: Did some of the fellas think that you needed to be high to play, to be able to keep up?

DK: Yeah. Which was a total myth. I think this is — speaks — this sociological problem, you're taking a psychiatrist, and I'm sure all of it's been written about, I'm not the one to do it but I don't know, when you look back and think of these guys that really self destructed, they are mental cases to start with somehow, to get into that, to allow themselves to get that way.

MR: So you can't just blame it on the music in other words.

DK: No. Because I have a feeling, no. And then there were other people, there was some musicians who almost craved anonymity, gifted, like Davey Schildkraut. You ever heard of him?

MR: Yeah.

DK: Well he was like this inside, and everybody, Stan Kenton was after him and I think he might have been with him for a minute and he quit. He just didn't want to deal with all that. He wound up working in a post office and talking about aliens. And then there's this terrific pianist, a friend of mine I haven't seen in years who lives out in Jersey and he just teaches and plays in bars. His name is Bill Trillia. He plays on a Mingus record. There's guys like that. And then there was this folk hero Tony Frasella, a little trumpet player, he'd carry his trumpet in a paper bag, and Don Joseph. These guys were like all little —

MR: Introverts.

DK: Introverted guys who played. And people make a cult out of it. You know what I'm saying? That they're sort of like — not Bix, because Bix played out you know. But they

were misfits, or whatever the word is now, I mean there's no question. Because the guys out there making it are like in any other field, they're asserting themselves on some level big time. And the best example I know of that, I was very privileged to have a front row seat to John Lewis and the MJQ because he was sort of my mentor, teacher, I used to go stay with him and my whole history with him would make an interview.

MR: Hopefully somebody will do a book on him.

DK: Yeah. They will. There is a French book on him, I was interviewed, while he was still alive, years ago, there was a French biography. But he was like a guy with a master plan. I saw it. It was like Khrushchev and the five year plan. He had this whole thing mapped out and nothing was going to stand in his way. He as this quiet, self-effacing man who was like a bull. He had a will of iron. Never raised his voice. Always got what he wanted. If you can tame Milt Jackson and Kenny Clarke, you're strong. And that's exactly what he did. Until Milt's dying day he had a lot of resentment about that whole experience, even though it made him a millionaire. But I think that's, I'll go on record as saying overall that's the greatest small ensemble in jazz history as a unit over a period of years. That music will last forever and they're sleeping on it and you don't hear about it now but you will. Because I saw how it worked, I saw how John made it work, and I — the way he made the compromises he deliberately made musically to get that sound which were misunderstood and the other thing, and the whole thing. And his model was sort of Duke Ellington, the dignity, the whole thing, where he wanted the group to go. It's an incredible story. I mean yes it should be, I'm sure it's been written about a lot. But he was a powerful influence on me.

MR: There's a record, the last concert, there's a moment on that record, a song called "One Never Knows"—

DK: [hums]

MR: There you go. I don't know, I can't even describe, the middle of that piece is so sublime or something that — it's like you said those people in the restaurant who would like pay attention when things went down. It's like it's so subtle but perfect.

DK: But John was like a benevolent dictator. We used to have some battles. See now I got — I don't know if it's on the record or off the record but I guess I could say this, like every mentor you come to a point where you have to cut the ties. Because he really had me Svengali — I'm glad he did because I learned a lot but there comes a point where you've got to say hold it, I've got to find me. Which I think I have. In the 60s, oh yeah, I went on the road with Philly Joe Jones.

MR: That must have been an experience.

DK: Oh boy. John warned me.

MR: Talk about a forceful personality.

DK: He — you know he was not just a gifted drummer, he could have been an actor, comedian, he used to do these — he was obsessed with Bela Lugosi and he used to do all these imitations, his voice and everything, and do all the routines from the movies. He made a record called "Dracula" of Philly Joe Jones and Dracula.

MR: Oh my God.

DK: Yeah. Of course he owes me money like he owes everybody else money. He had his drug thing. I think he beat it, or at least — I never was clear if he actually really beat it forever. I don't know if he ever went back. But John warned me about — John got very angry with me because I was going to go join him. He said, "You can't do that, he's a gangster, you don't know those people." He was like a father, he was saying you're nuts, you can't do that. I said I'm going, I went. It wasn't that long, a couple of months or whatever it was. And it was quite an experience.

MR: What's the worst scrape you ever got into? Can you recall?

DK: Oh, scrape?

MR: Or unpleasant situation.

DK: I can't really think about it. I mean I can think of some scenes I had with various musicians but nothing — I mean I can think of humiliations I suffered, of my own making. Like this one record I was on I would love to burn. I won't tell you what it was. Two actually. I just — one I hadn't touched a piano for like three weeks or something and I went up there thinking I don't have to play and they called me up to play and I was all thumbs.

MR: But they put it out anyway of course.

DK: They put it out anyway. So I've been about 70 or so records I guess.

MR: Let me ask you, well I don't mean ask you, I said I'm going to pick out one thing that you played on and just bring it with me. It's a hard thing, when you've played on so many recordings. But —

DK: Oh, you're asking me—

MR: I have it right here.

DK: Oh really?

MR: And I want you to just see if you — maybe you won't even recognize what it is.

[audio interlude]

DK: Yeah I know what that is. That's Benny Carter's "Further Definitions." What is that "Crazy Rhythm?"

MR: Yeah, very good. Nice album.

DK: Sounds better on here.

MR: It's right off the LP.

DK: Oh I'll tell you an anecdote connected with this record, that I'm very proud of. You must have a newer — is this the two—

MR: I'll show you the album later.

DK: Is this the one that has the other one in it too?

MR: No, I don't think so.

DK: Yeah I'd like to see if it's the same one I have because that piano sounds better here than it does on mine. Anyhow during that record date, I don't even know how I got on the date because I hadn't met Benny Carter before then. I knew everybody else in the band, except John Collins, I didn't know him, but I had played with Jimmy Garrison, with Philly Joe, I had worked with Jo Jones a lot, I worked with Phil Woods, I worked with his group with Gene Quill. And Charlie Rouse I don't know if I'd ever worked with but probably jammed with him or something. Who else is one there? And Coleman Hawkins I had played with. I played with Coleman Hawkins at Newport the first time. J.J., Coleman Hawkins and Buck Clayton.

MR: The Buck Clayton All-Stars.

DK: Yeah. George Avakian put that together on the spur of the moment. And also there is a very obscure album which should be reissued. Warner Brothers is doing some jazz in the late 50s or early 60s, and there was this guy named Bob Prince, an arranger, and he did these two oddball albums. One was — I think it was twelve trombones or something, it was all trombones. Then there's one that's called Saxophones Incorporated, and it was twelve saxophones I think. And it sounded like a big band. You didn't even miss the brass the way he arranged it. And every guy in it was a hotshot. And I remember Georgie Auld played on it and Coleman Hawkins came in to do a feature. And there is an interesting story that goes with this because the arranger, Bob Prince, Coleman didn't have to read or anything, they just said, "What do you want to play on this record, your featured solo, I'll write the arrangement around whatever you want to do." And he says, "Well how about 'The Gypsy?'" You know that song? I think Bird was playing it. And Bob Prince didn't know it, so he asked Coleman to sing it to him. So when Coleman sang it he sang the bridge in long meter, it was twice as many bars, and that's the way he arranged it. It came out great. So Coleman came in, I'll never forget it, and it hat on — he played one take. Flawless. He said, "Can I hear that back? Okay. Thanks a lot fellas, bye." Walked out. That was that. I never seen that happen before. Usually everybody's sweating over it. So that was a nice record. It almost disappeared. You wanted to ask me a question about that? Or you just wanted to do the blindfold test?

MR: No, I just wanted to see if you remembered it, and if it was a good date for you.

DK: Oh, the story that goes with that date. It was very relaxed and I remember Coleman, I think he might have been wearing a tux because he was working in the Metropole or

something. It was very nice. We did it in two days, a lot of musicians there, and Benny Carter's music plays itself. But now this is a class man, this Benny Carter. Because listen to what he did. On one of the tunes I had the bridge to play a little solo. Just eight bars I think. And I played it. I don't remember which tune, it was probably "Honeysuckle Rose." So when I did it Bob Thiele from the control room, after we did the take he says, "Uh Dick, can we have a little Count Basie in that spot?" Benny Carter took the microphone and says, "Bob if you don't mind I'd like to hear a little Dick Katz in that place." Now that was, to me, historic, because the overwhelming majority of the times, white or black, they want to please, whatever the guy said, do it. Do what he says.

MR: The producer?

DK: Do what the producer says. Very often. They don't want any trouble. It didn't make that much difference for something like that. You know Tyree Glen would have said play Count Basie. The one time I rebelled at the end of a Warner — Danny Kaye had a terrific arrangement, I forget which tune, it might have been "Sandman" or something, and they had that [scats Basie ending] and I refused to play it. I played the rhythm but I changed the voicing. I just couldn't bring myself to do it. Because even then it was like the cliché of all time.

MR: I guess. And it always will be.

DK: Yeah. So okay, where are we?

MR: Oh well, I wanted to ask you a little bit about Gunther Schuller.

DK: Oh yeah I was involved with him. Yeah if I had to pick highlights, and interesting experiences, and you ask me about a — what was it, an anxiety-producing – what was that question?

MR: Yes. Well I called it — I forget what I called it. I can't remember now. An anxious moment.

DK: Oh yes, we've all had many anxious moments. But one, a lot of them involved John Lewis, but well I had anxious moments with Gunther. These are musical things. Well I was involved in the Orchestra USA. One time we had to play a Webern piece. See we were playing all kinds of music. And I'm not really classical, and I had to play the celeste. And this was one of those times where, like the guy with the cymbal, you just count until your — it was just a few little notes I had to play in this spot in this Webern piece. I was an absolute nervous wreck waiting, if I was going to make it, counting all these bars in this complicated, Gunther — and he practically stood over me, he kind of practically did it for me and I made it. It was a very anxious moment.

MR: I know what you mean. Those orchestra things, man, 86 measures — I'm a saxophone player.

DK: Oh okay.

MR: So you know on occasion when there's a saxophone part in an orchestra, you're waiting and waiting, and you say I hope to God he gives me a cue because I lost it and I hope it's the right cue. And it's always a solo, of course, after waiting all that time.

DK: Yeah.

MR: So it's just you.

DK: Well I had anxious moments like that. One time I sat in with Roland used to send me in to sub with Thad Jones and Mel Lewis. And that book is in tatters, it was then. He knew the book by heart. He'd been there forever after Hank. So, and he played this prank. He was a prankster in those days.

MR: Roland Hanna?

DK: Oh God. Could you go in and sub for me tonight? I have to write some music for "The Today Show." That sounded funny to me anyhow. I mean "The Tonight Show." So I went in and I'm scuffling, and there was one piece, it's either "Once Around" or "Three in One," Brookmeyer. You're going along, it's a very abstract piece, and all of a sudden the band stops. Silence. And it says on the part "Play a solo." No chords, nothing. Just play. And I had heard guys do that. And most guys like try out everything they ever knew, they go crazy. The record is — Hank is on the record. And what he played there is — you could play in any classroom. I mean it was so perfect, and the way he brought the band in. And I was pretty nervous about that, and stuff like that. Another time I wasn't supposed to play. Okay he's got to change the tape — oh ten minutes okay. Can you edit this stuff out?

MR: Yes we can.

DK: I've got to remember that Fats Waller story, which album I wrote it in, because I don't know if it was Carmen's or not and it's bugging me what it was. Because what would be the connection. Okay. Boing, the bell went on. I wrote the notes to — Orrin Keepnews who was my partner in Milestone Records gave me a certain amount of work when he started doing all these reissues. And one of the assignments was not too many years ago in the 90s, was a Fats Waller compilation, which was fun, because I loved all that. So in the introduction to those notes, I told the Fats Waller story when I was a kid about going down in the basement, that's where it comes from, in the Royal Theater and all of that. So it's not Carmen McRae. Because what I told in the Carmen notes was my experiences with her at Minton's. And how I came to play there and the whole thing with her and when I went to make the album for Decca there was a little guy with glasses sitting in the audience who turned out to be Billy Strayhorn. And he came up and played "Something to Live For" for her. And you know who hired me for that record? Kenny Clarke? I was working with him at the Bohemia at the time. Interestingly, not too many years before

that he was married to Carmen, so there he was leading this date for her so they became friends I guess eventually.

MR: So what did you decide to play in that spot in the Thad Jones?

DK: I'll never — I can't remember. Another time I also had a very pleasing experience for about six years from 1986 to about '91, '92 with the American Jazz Orchestra, which is a wonderful repertory orchestra that was started by Gary Giddins and we played at Cooper Union and John Lewis was the musical director, and Gunther came in one time and we did an Ellington triptych, well that was a trying experience with him because Gunther, if you see this I'm going to complain because I had a terrible time reading Duke's comp, where he wrote out the comp.

MR: Oh I'll bet.

DK: It came out, anyhow, I thought it came out good. I listened to those tapes recently, they sound pretty good. But it was very trying to read that kind of stuff. And some guys just read that right off. I'm not a world class reader. I can read, particularly if I get a little peek at it ahead of time I'm okay, but I'm not a studio style sight reader. There were some trying moments with John, we had a misunderstanding about whether I was supposed to play or not at a Dizzy concert and I wound up playing and he told me, never mind. I mumbled through this one. We smoothed it out. The most exciting time with the orchestra was in 1987 they invited Benny Carter to come and conduct a concert entirely of his music and write a new suite for the occasion. And the album, and we did it, a wonderful concert, everybody played great and then we went in the studio and did the album which is still available, which I highly recommend, it's called "Central City Sketches." American Jazz Orchestra. I'm pretty pleased with my part in that. And I'd like to mention something that was a highlight of my recording career, I'd like to mention. In the 60s I got involved with a wonderful singer named Helen Merrill. And we used to work a lot in those days, you know we used to work at the Vanguard. One time I had a gig there, this is an interesting story, it was Helen and I and my trio with Ben Riley, who's, he's my favorite right now, and a wonderful bass player named Tommy Williams who has since passed away. The other attraction was the Bill Evans Trio. Okay? And we had a quartet which included Thad Jones. We had been there a week and Max Gordon says, "The trumpet player plays funny," he says, "we don't' really need him, do we?" He says, "What do you need a trumpet for?" You know Bill Evans is there. Why don't you — I said sorry, it's not about to happen, I'm not going fire Thad Jones. He said, "Well I think Ben Webster is available." No. Sorry. I can't do that. So we got together and we said to Thad we'll pay your salary, we'll both chip in, if you stay. And Thad says no. And he didn't play the second week. And very shortly after that the Thad Jones-Mel Lewis Monday night thing started and he stayed there — they're still there without them. And

that was — but anyhow Helen and I started rehearsing and about this time I didn't know Orrin Keepnews that well. But, and he's not that accessible a person until you get to know him. He's not a "hail fellow well met" like — he's very much an individual and he can have a dour, but he's a great, great man but he's not somebody going to slap you on the back say how you doing you know. So we ran into each other, our sons went to the same school. So Father's Day I ran into him up there. We got to talking and he was going through this spectacular bankruptcy of Riverside Records. And he was about to be out of a job. And he was over qualified, trying to get a job, when he went to all these companies he would get letters saying you're too qualified for a job like this and we don't have a job upstairs. So he was having a hard time. So I had always had a thing in the back of my mind I'd like to try my hand at producing records, I had a lot of ideas. Some of it came from John, he had so many ideas about how to make records and stuff. And so what I did is I went to my brother-in-law and borrowed $10,000 and we started this little label called Milestone. Can you imagine? And to make a long story short we made some really nice records. Now meantime I had borrowed money, Helen and I wanted to do this record. And we had rehearsed all this stuff and we picked out all these songs and I wrote these charts and I hired Thad Jones and Jim Hall and Ron Carter and Pete LaRoca and myself. And we went in and did this. I hired, George Avakian did it for no money hardly, we made these tapes and they came out great, and we tried to sell them, nobody wanted them. Can you imagine? So when we started Milestone that was one of the first records we put out. Then five stars.

MR: All right.

DK: Oh yeah. And I'm very proud of that record. And then we made a sequel in 1968. By then Milestone is up and running and she made a deal with Japanese Victor, they owned the tape — no she owns the tape but they had the rights for America, or some kind of complicated deal. And we did that one with the same cast except Elvin Jones played the drums and I added Hubert Laws and I also made those charts. Then we made a third record in 1980 was it or '79 for another label called — a now defunct label called Inner City but it had another life in Japan and came back out here, and that's called "Chasing the Bird" and that's with Pepper. It's all Gershwin. And Pepper Adams and Joe Puma, Mel Lewis and Rufus Reid. So she sang these Gershwins and I also made the charts on that. Where two of the tracks, like one she sings "I Got Rhythm" straight and we played "Chasing the Bird" behind her, and then she sang "Embraceable You" and we'd play "Quassimodo." So those three records I'm very proud of, particularly the first two. Now they have been reissued in France a year or so ago and they're doing all right and she's having a terrible time getting them — I can't, I've been trying to help her too, getting

them reissued here. It seems to be not easy. But we're hoping, soon. Those records I'll stand on.

MR: Well you've had an amazing run at it, and you're still doing it.

DK: Yeah still doing it, you know not as often but not that much work. See if I left out any big thing. I probably have but—

MR: Well we could do part two down the road, all right?

DK: All right.

MR: If you have some other things to talk about.

DK: For the last several years I've been writing a musical with a guy.

MR: All right. Well I hope I see it on Broadway.

DK: We do too. I'm not a Broadway person but he asked me, this guy, he writes for the *New York Times* his name is Barry Singer.

MR: All right. Well this has been fascinating for me. I really appreciate your coming and thanks for your time.

DK: It's been fun. Yeah. I probably editorialized too much.

MR: No I don't think so. I love some of the stuff you were saying and we really probably could do another session.

DK: Yeah, is there any chance that I could hear what I wanted out of this?

MR: Yes.